
Where NETPRO Stands

An honest look at our school system, measured against the best in the world — and what it would take to join them.

Prepared for — Living Temple Academy and the NETPRO team

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Based on — a review of 27 sources, including nine competing products, government guidance and independent university studies, checked against a full inspection of our own software

START HERE

The short version

If you read only one page, read this one.

We built a school system that does the everyday work of a school well. Students, staff, classes, attendance, results, exams, fees, the library, timetables, messages, notices. All of it works, and one part of it — the part that keeps working when the internet does not — is genuinely better than what the big international companies sell.

But the everyday work is only the entry level. When you look at what schools in Britain, America and Australia actually buy, the register and the report card are the *starting* tier. The things they pay extra for are the things we do not have at all.

There are four gaps serious enough to stop a sale, and one of them is serious enough to stop a child being protected.

Protecting children	We have nowhere to record a concern about a child. No log, no history, no record of who was told or what was decided. This is the single biggest gap and it is not a feature — in most countries it is the price of entry.
Health and medicine	We record a child's religion and their old school. We do not record that they are allergic to peanuts.
The front door	Everything in the system — every child's address, every family's finances — sits behind a six-character password and nothing else.
Language	The system speaks English only, and there is no way to add another language without going back through every screen.

None of these is hard to understand. All of them are expensive to ignore.

WHAT WE WOULD DO FIRST

Fix the front door, build the child-protection record, and make it possible to add a second language later. Those three, in that order, before anything else. Two of them protect children; the third gets cheaper the sooner it is done and more expensive every single week it is delayed.

CONTENTS

What is in this document

Nine short sections. You can read them in any order.

1 • How we checked

Why you can trust the findings, and where you should not

2 • What we have built

An honest inventory

3 • The one thing we do better

Working without internet

4 • Protecting children

The biggest gap, and what filling it means

5 • Health, allergies and medicine

The gap nobody notices until the day it matters

6 • Locking the front door

Passwords, and who can get in

7 • The truth about automation and AI

What the evidence actually shows

8 • Phones

What parents and teachers should be able to do

9 • What to do, in what order

And the decisions only you can make

SECTION 1

How we checked

A short note on method, because it changes how much weight to put on what follows.

We did two things. First, we went through our own software line by line and wrote down exactly what it does and does not do. That part is simply fact — it is our code, and we can see it.

Second, we researched what the best school systems in the world actually offer. We read the published material of nine competing products, government guidance from the UK Department for Education, and independent studies run by universities and government research bodies.

Then we did something less usual. Every claim we gathered was challenged — deliberately argued against, three times over, to see whether it held up. Twenty-five claims went through that process and **eleven of them did not survive**. Several were the ones we had most expected to be true.

That matters, because a lot of what is written about school software is marketing. One company claims a result fifteen times larger than the best independent study of the same thing has ever measured. If we had not checked, we would have repeated it.

WHERE WE ARE GUESSING

We should be straight about the limits. Our research covered child protection, government reporting and the evidence on automation well. It covered several other areas **not at all** — data-protection law, school transport, catering, boarding, and what the law requires of a company like ours rather than of a school.

Where this document is confident, it says so. Where it is our judgement rather than something we verified, it says that too. Anything about legal obligations in particular should be checked with a lawyer before you act on it — we are telling you what our software does not do, not what the law says it must.

SECTION 2

What we have built

More than it might feel like. Just not, yet, the parts that win contracts abroad.

The system runs four separate portals — one each for the office, teachers, students and parents — across a little over a hundred screens. It handles:

- Students, parents, teachers and office staff, with their records and histories
- Classes, arms, subjects, terms and sessions
- Daily attendance, including a check on which registers were never taken
- Marks and results, with an approval step so nothing reaches a parent before the school has agreed it
- Computer-based tests that teachers write and mark
- Fees, invoices, a cashier's desk, receipts, spending records and online card payment
- The library, including lending, returns and fines
- Timetables, notices, and two-way messages between families and staff
- Dashboards, performance analysis, and a record of who changed what

That is a real product, and a coherent one. A school can run on it.

But set it beside what a mature British system sells, and the shape becomes clear. Their cheapest tier contains roughly what we have. Their middle tier adds behaviour records, clubs and trips, meals. Their top tier — the one they charge most for — contains staff training records and **child protection**.

In their terms, we have built the entry tier, with a fee system suited to an African school added on top. We have none of the middle tier and none of the top.

Here is the plain list of what does not exist. Not "works badly" — is not there at all:

MISSING ENTIRELY	WHO FEELS IT
Child protection records	Every school, every regulator, every parent
Medical conditions, allergies, medication	The child who needs an injection
Behaviour and pastoral records	Teachers and heads of year
Support plans for children with additional needs	Those children and their families
Admissions — enquiries through to enrolment	The school's own income
Staff: payroll, leave, appraisal, training	The bursar and the head
Transport and buses	Parents of every child who rides one

MISSING ENTIRELY	WHO FEELS IT
Meals and the kitchen	Catering, and children with dietary needs
Boarding	Any school with boarders
Alumni and fundraising	The school's long-term finances
Government and ministry returns	Whoever signs the school's statutory forms
Second language, right-to-left text	Every family that does not read English comfortably
Connections to other school software	Any buyer outside Nigeria

SECTION 3

The one thing we do better

Worth understanding properly, because it is our strongest card and it is easy to undersell.

Almost every school system in the world assumes the internet works. Ours does not.

In our system, everything a teacher needs is already stored on their own device. Open the register in a classroom with no signal and the full class list is there. Mark thirty children. Close the laptop. The marks are safe on the machine, and the moment a connection appears they go to the school's server on their own.

This is not a small technical detail and it is not a fallback mode. It is how the whole system is built, and it took real engineering to do. When we checked what the big international products offer, **not one of them advertises this**. Their parent and teacher apps expect a connection and stop being useful without one.

For schools in Nigeria that difference is the product. A register that cannot be taken because the network is down is not a register.

THE HONEST COST

This advantage is not free. Because every part of the system has to work offline, every new feature costs more to build than it would in an ordinary system. Every gap listed in this document is a more expensive gap for us than it would be for a competitor.

That is worth knowing before planning the work, not discovering halfway through it. It is a price worth paying — but it should be budgeted rather than stumbled into.

One caution on how strongly to claim this. We verified it against four competitors in detail. We did not check every product in the world. "None of the systems we examined offers this" is true and defensible. "No system in the world offers this" is not something we can prove.

SECTION 4

Protecting children

The largest gap in the product, and the one that should be filled first.

When a teacher notices something worrying about a child — a bruise, a comment, a change in behaviour, a child who keeps arriving hungry — that observation needs to go somewhere. Not into a notebook, not into a WhatsApp message, not into a conversation in a corridor. Into a record.

Our system has nowhere for it to go.

What the good systems do

The standard everywhere we looked is the same, and it is more than a notes field. It is a **timeline for each child**, built up over years, which gathers every small concern, every conversation, every letter, every meeting and every decision into one place, in order, each stamped with the date and the person who wrote it.

The point of a timeline rather than a list of separate incidents is that harm to a child rarely looks like one obvious event. It looks like six small things over two years that no single person saw together. Put in order, they tell a story. Kept apart, they are six forgettable notes.

One detail stood out, and it is the one most systems get wrong. The guidance expects a school to record not only the decisions to act, but the decisions **not** to act — and the reasoning. If someone senior looked at a concern and decided not to refer it to social services, that judgement and its reasons must be written down. It is the hardest thing to remember to record and the most important thing to have later.

What this means for how we build it

Three things follow, and they are unusual enough to state plainly.

These records must not be stored on the device. Everything else in our system is deliberately kept on the user's own machine so it works offline. For child protection that would be dangerous — a staff-room laptop that several people share would be holding children's disclosures. So this one part of the system works the opposite way from all the rest, on purpose.

Almost nobody can read them. A teacher can report a concern and then cannot see it again, cannot see the child's history, and cannot see what anyone decided. They are told their report was received, and that is all. Only the person responsible for child protection and their deputies see the record itself.

The fact that a record exists is itself confidential. No marker on the class list, no coloured row, no badge. If a teacher can tell at a glance which children have a file, the confidentiality is already gone.

THIS IS NOT A BUILD-ONCE JOB

The official guidance behind all of this is **rewritten every year** and takes effect each September. A system built once against this year's rules is wrong by next September. That has to be designed in from the first day — old records must keep the categories they were filed under, even after those categories change.

ONE THING WE WILL NOT DO

Some products offer software that scans what children write — their messages, their essays — looking for worrying words. We are not proposing that, and we would push back if asked.

It means monitoring every child all the time on the chance of catching something, the evidence that it works is contested, and it would turn every message in our system into material to be searched. If a school wants it, that is a separate decision to be taken deliberately and with proper legal advice — not something to slip in as a feature.

Finally, an honesty point. We found it claimed that child-protection guidance legally obliges a *software company* to provide these tools. We checked, and that is not right — the legal duty sits on the school, not on us. We should build this because schools cannot do their job without it and will not buy a system that lacks it. That is reason enough. We should not claim it is the law.

SECTION 5

Health, allergies and medicine

The gap nobody notices until the afternoon it matters.

Our student record has room for a child's religion, their previous school, their birth certificate and their O-level results. It has nowhere to record that peanuts will kill them.

This one is simple to describe and hard to defend leaving out.

The scenario that drives the design

A supply teacher, covering a class they do not normally teach, takes thirty children on a trip. They are in a field. There is no phone signal. One child is having an allergic reaction.

That teacher needs to know, in seconds, which child carries an adrenaline injector and where it is kept. Everything about how we build this follows from that single moment.

It means the emergency information has to be the **opposite** of the child-protection records in section 4. Those are hidden and never stored on the device. This must be visible to whoever is responsible for the child right now, and it must be on the device, because the field has no signal.

We resolve that by splitting the information in two.

THE EMERGENCY CARD	THE FULL HEALTH RECORD
Photo, name, class, the life-threatening conditions, what to do, where the medicine physically is , who to call. Stored on the device. Readable offline by any teacher responsible for that child today, including cover staff.	Everything else — history, diagnoses, letters, medication given, immunisations. Not stored on the device. Only the school's health lead can see it. Every time someone opens it, that is recorded.

The card deliberately contains almost nothing. "Peanuts — severe allergy — injector in the front office, red box" is the whole useful content. A child's eczema, mental health history or family circumstances are not emergencies and do not belong on it.

Giving medicine

This is the part where software can actually injure a child, so it is worth being blunt about the rules we would set.

- **The system never calculates a dose.** No converting units, no working it out from a child's weight, no rounding. If the prescription says 5ml, the screen says 5ml and nothing else.
- **The child is identified by photograph, not by name.** Two children with similar names and one wrong dose is the defining accident here.

- **A refusal must be recordable.** If a child refuses their medicine, or was missed, that has to be enterable with a reason. A form that only accepts "given" produces false records, because the person filling it in has to put something.
- **An expired emergency medicine raises an alarm,** not a line in a list. An out-of-date injector in the box on the day it is needed is the clearest preventable death this whole module exists to stop.

BEFORE ANY OF THIS IS BUILT

A school nurse or someone equivalently qualified must review the medicine section. We wrote it from first principles and careful reasoning, not from a medical standard, and our research did not verify a single claim in this area. It is the part of this whole document we are least entitled to be confident about.

SECTION 6

Locking the front door

Unglamorous, cheap to fix, and currently the weakest thing in the system.

Our software holds children's names, addresses, dates of birth, photographs, where they are every day, how they are doing, and what their families owe. Once we build the two things described above, it will also hold child protection disclosures and medical records.

The way in is a six-character password. There is nothing else.

There is no second step, no code from a phone, no way to sign in with a Google or Microsoft school account. Nobody can see where their account is signed in, or sign out a lost phone. Sessions never time out — a laptop left open in a staff room stays open.

And one small thing that is worse than it sounds: **a member of staff who thinks their password has been stolen cannot change it from inside the system.** There is no screen for it. They have to go out through the "forgot password" email process. Adding that screen is a few days' work and it should be done regardless of everything else here.

What we would change

Longer passwords, fewer silly rules. Our current rules demand a capital, a number and a symbol but allow six characters. That combination is the worst of both worlds — short enough to guess, with rules that push people towards `Passw0rd!`. Modern thinking is the reverse: make them longer, drop the fiddly requirements. Existing users would not be locked out; they would be asked to update next time they sign in.

A second step, but not for everybody. This is the important decision. It would be a mistake to force every parent to set up an authenticator app. A grandmother with a basic phone who cannot complete it is a grandmother locked out of her grandchild's attendance and school fees. That is real harm, done to the least technical people, to solve a risk they mostly do not carry.

So we would require it of the accounts that hold everything — the head, the bursar, the office, the child protection lead, the health lead. Recommend it strongly for teachers, whose marks are the thing students most want to change. Offer it to parents and students, and leave it their choice.

Sessions that lock themselves. With one careful detail: locking must not mean signing out. Signing out wipes the school's data from that device — which is right for a shared machine, but wiping a teacher's unsent register because they went to lunch would be a disaster. It locks; it does not erase.

A "shared device" mode. The most common risk in a school is not a hacker. It is a signed-in laptop in a staff room that four people use. A session marked as being on a

shared machine would keep nothing when the browser closes, time out quickly, and ask for the password again before anything sensitive opens.

ORDER MATTERS HERE

This section should be finished **before** child protection and health records are switched on. Those records behind a six-character password, with no timeout and no second step, would be worse than not having them at all — because the school would believe those children's records were safe.

SECTION 7

The truth about automation and "AI"

This section will save money. It is the part of the research that most contradicts what the industry says.

Everyone selling school software now sells automation: systems that predict which children are at risk, that text parents automatically when a child is absent, that spot problems before a teacher does. The marketing is confident and the numbers are large.

We looked at the independent evidence. It is much more modest, and in places it flatly contradicts the sales material.

Texting parents about absence

Six proper trials, six school districts, more than 78,000 children. Automatically texting parents about their child's attendance reduced absences by **about 1.9 per cent**.

One company selling exactly this product advertises a **28 per cent** reduction, based on its own uncontrolled analysis. That is roughly fifteen times the best independent estimate.

1.9%

Measured

Six randomised trials, 78,000+ children, published in an academic journal

28%

Advertised

One vendor's own analysis of its own messages, with no control group

A second, larger government study found the same shape: real but small improvements in attendance, and **no improvement at all** in reading or mathematics.

Predicting which children are at risk

A large trial across 73 secondary schools and nearly 38,000 students found that an early-warning system did reduce two things: children being persistently absent fell from 14 per cent to 10, and course failures from 26 per cent to 21. Those are worthwhile.

But the same study found **no improvement** in grades, in suspensions, or in whether students were on track to graduate. The organisation that developed the system titled its own press release "Helps Get Students on Path to Graduation". The number for being on track to graduate was 14 per cent in both groups. Identical.

Two further details are worth more than the headline. The system produced its gains even though **95 per cent of the schools using it were judged to have implemented it badly**. And the researchers said plainly that they do not know which actions by staff caused the improvement. So the evidence supports "running an early-warning programme helped" — not "the software caused it".

A FINDING WE SHOULD NOT BUILD WITHOUT

A government study compared simple rule-based warnings against a machine-learning system. The machine-learning version was better in narrow circumstances. But **both were measurably less accurate for Black students** than for others.

That study was American, so the specific groups do not transfer directly to a Nigerian school. The lesson does. These systems are not equally accurate for every group of children, and using a cleverer algorithm does not fix it.

Our position should be: if we ship a system that labels a child "at risk", we ship the evidence of how accurate it is for different groups of children alongside it. Without that we are making unexamined judgements about children and calling it insight.

So what should we do?

Build both. We already hold the attendance and the results, so they are cheap to add, and a 1.9 per cent improvement in attendance is still children in school who otherwise were not.

But describe them honestly. A school told "this will cut absence by a quarter" and then seeing almost no change will not renew. A school told "this reliably produces a small improvement, at very little effort" gets what it was promised.

One practical finding to design around: in the larger study, **staff texting parents personally worked better than the fully automatic version** for the children at highest risk. The right design is automation as the baseline, with a human following up the difficult cases — not automation instead of a person.

SECTION 8

Phones

What a parent and a teacher should be able to do, and why a phone app is worth building at all.

Our system already works on a phone through the browser, and it already works offline. So the usual reason for building a phone app does not apply to us. It is worth being clear about what a real app would add, because there are only four things — and they are enough.

1. **Telling a parent something while the app is closed.** A parent should learn their child was marked absent at 8:40 without opening anything. Today that is impossible. It is the single most valuable thing a parent app does anywhere in the world.
2. **Not being forgotten.** iPhones delete a website's stored data after about a week of not visiting. A parent who checks the portal once a term starts from nothing every time. A proper app is not erased.
3. **The camera, the fingerprint reader, and somewhere safe to keep the login.**
4. **Being findable.** To a parent, a web address is not a product. An entry in the app store is.

Anything not on that list should stay on the website.

For parents

Four questions, over and over: is my child in school today, what did they score, what do I owe, and what is the school telling me. The app should answer those four in one tap each, and everything else can be two taps further away.

For families with several children at the school, whose child you are looking at must be unmistakable at all times. Misreading which child's result is on screen is the classic failure of parent apps.

For teachers

The app is the register, and it will be judged on that alone. It should open to today's class, with the full list already on screen, from the device, with no connection, in under two seconds. Marking a child should be one tap. There should be a "everyone is here, now let me correct it" button, because that is how registers are actually taken.

We would build the teacher app first. It is where working offline matters most, the audience is small enough to get honest feedback from, and better attendance data is what makes the parent app worth opening.

ONE THING TO GUARD AGAINST

A phone app makes it easier for staff and parents to contact each other directly, outside the school's systems. That should be made harder, not easier. The app should never show a parent's personal phone number or offer to ring it.

Conversations between staff and families belong on the school's own record, where they can be seen if there is ever a question.

What to do, in what order

And the decisions that are yours rather than ours.

First — the things that stop a sale or embarrass us

1. **The front door.** The password-change screen immediately, then longer passwords, then a second step for the accounts that hold everything.
2. **Child protection, and health.** In that order, and only once the front door is done.
3. **Notifications on phones.** This unlocks the parent app entirely; without it there is little point building one.
4. **Prepare for a second language.** Not translate — prepare. Explained below.

Then — the things that win the next market

Government and ministry reporting; exam boards; admissions; behaviour records; support plans for children with additional needs; and the attendance automation from section 7, described honestly.

Later — breadth

Staff and payroll, transport, meals, boarding, alumni, and the connections that let other school software talk to ours.

WHY LANGUAGE IS URGENT EVEN THOUGH IT SEEMS MINOR

Everything in the system is written in English, in over a hundred screens, with the English woven directly into the working parts rather than kept separately. Adding a language later means going back through all of it.

It is the only item on this list whose cost **rises every single week we keep building**. Every screen added before we separate the words out is another screen to go back through. Every screen added afterwards is free. That is the entire argument, and it is why it sits in the first group despite being the least urgent-sounding thing here.

Decisions we need from you

Who reviews the medical section?

We cannot build it on our own authority. It needs a nurse or equivalent.

Who is the child protection lead at the school, and who covers them?

The design assumes a named person exists and that someone senior is contactable when they are not available.

Which language first, and who writes it?	This needs someone who can <i>write</i> in that language, not just translate. That person may be harder to find than the budget.
Nigerian Pidgin — access or condescension?	Very widely spoken, rarely written formally. Badly done it would insult the people it is meant to help. A native speaker should decide this, not us.
What may we honestly promise about the attendance and at-risk features?	Given section 7, this is a decision about what we are willing to say to a school — not a technical question.
How much does selling outside Nigeria matter, and how soon?	It changes the order of almost everything. Connecting to other systems is pointless for a Nigerian school and essential for a British one.

A closing note

It would be easy to read this document as a list of failures. It is not one. We have built something that does the daily work of a school properly, and one part of it — keeping working when the internet does not — is better than what much larger companies sell.

What the research shows is that we have built the foundation and stopped at the point where the international market begins. The gaps are clear, they are known, and most of them are ordinary work. Two of them are about children's safety, and those should be done first and carefully.

The one thing we would ask is this: when these features are built, describe them honestly. The most striking thing in the whole review was how far the marketing in this industry has drifted from the evidence. There is an opportunity in simply not doing that.

Prepared September 2026 · Based on 27 sources, 25 claims independently checked, 11 rejected